

The Good Ideas That Shaped My Investment Philosophy

BAD IDEAS ARE everywhere. The antidote is vigilance—and good ideas. In physics and mathematics, philosophy and investing, we can “see further,” to paraphrase Isaac Newton, “by standing on the shoulders of giants.”

In mostly chronological order, these concepts have helped shape my worldview, including how I think about the economy, markets, and investing.

1. “I write to discover what I think. (After all, the bars aren’t open that early.)”—Daniel J. Boorstin

As librarian of the United States Congress, Boorstin understood the power of the written word. It’s a crucial aspect of how I formed my own belief system.

Writing helps me organize my thoughts. It creates a record of what I believed at a specific date—and (hopefully) shows my evolution over time. Sharing my thoughts in public invites comments, criticism, and debate from others who have thought through similar issues. This forces me to sharpen my views about markets, the economy and money.

2. “Ninety percent of everything is crap.”—Ted Sturgeon

Weary of defending science fiction against attacks from those who used the worst examples in the field, Sturgeon pointed out that most human endeavors are filled with garbage. It’s not just sci-fi, but 90% of *everything* is worthless junk.

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